

Sprint2: Personas and User Stories

Student Personas

Student Persona A: Rory

Rory 	• First-year undergraduate student • Stressed about coursework and deadlines • Shy and fragile	• Support thread • Booking
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Role/User type: First-Year Undergraduate student

Bio: Rory is a university student who often feels stressed about coursework and deadlines. She sometimes wants advice or emotional support but feels uncomfortable talking about personal concerns with friends or visiting counselling services in person.

Goals:

- To seek help in a private and less intimidating way
- To receive guidance when feeling overwhelmed

Pain Points:

- She is sometimes unsure whether her concerns are serious enough to seek help
- Booking appointments with support services feels difficult and time-consuming

Story ID: S1

- Feature: **Support Thread**
- Title: My Support Thread
 - User story
 - As a student, I want to submit a support request privately, so that I can ask for help without feeling embarrassed or judged.
 - As a student, I want to receive replies from a counsellor in the same conversation thread, so that I can follow the advice and continue the conversation if needed.
 - Acceptance Criteria

- **Given:** I am on the Support page, **When:** I type a message and click '**Start a New Request**', **Then:** A new thread should be created, and my message should be displayed with a timestamp.
- **Given:** I have an open thread, **When:** A counsellor replies, **Then:** Their message should appear within the same thread.
- Priority
 - Must
- Justification of prioritisation /Trade-off
 - **Bridges the Gap:** Categorized as a "Must" because it addresses the core "fragile-type" student demographic that currently avoids support service
 - **Trade-off:** Prioritizes immediate booking over complex rescheduling tools to ensure the initial step of seeking help is as frictionless as possible.

Story ID: S2

- Feature: **Booking**
- Title: Low-Pressure Well-being Activity Booking
 - User story
 - As a student who feels intimidated by formal 1-on-1 counseling, I want to browse and book well-being activities (such as workshops or group sessions) so that I can access mental health support in a low-pressure, less clinical environment that feels safe for me.
 - Acceptance Criteria
 - **Given:** I am on the booking page, **When:** I view the available support options, **Then:** I should see a clear category for "Well-being Activities" alongside traditional counselling slots.
 - **Given:** I have an existing activity booking, **When:** I view my profile, **Then:** I should be able to see, edit, or cancel my participation details easily.
 - Priority
 - Must
 - Justification of prioritisation /Trade-off
 - **Bridges the Gap:** This is a "Must" because it provides a vital entry point for "fragile-type" students like Rory who currently avoid formal services due to anxiety.
 - **Lowers the Threshold:** By prioritizing group-based or low-intensity activities, we reduce the emotional burden of seeking help, ensuring the first step toward recovery is as frictionless as possible.

Jack 	Second-year undergraduate student - Overwhelmed by his academic and personal commitments - Prefers efficient booking and speaking in person	Booking FAQ (start a new support thread directly if a solution is not found)
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Role/User type: Second-Year Undergraduate student

Bio: Jack is a busy student currently feeling completely overwhelmed by his academic and personal commitments. Unlike students who are hesitant to reach out, Jack is actively looking for direct assistance and prefers speaking with someone in person to resolve his issues quickly.

Goals:

- To get mental health support immediately
- To find quick help that fits into his hectic schedule

Pain points:

- Feeling "overwhelmed" and needing urgent intervention
- Does not want to waste time on complex or slow communication methods

Story ID: S3

- Feature: [Booking](#)
- Title: Fast-Track Face-to-Face Booking
 - User story
 - As a student, I want to book an appointment so I can talk to an advisor face-to-face and get direct support
 - Acceptance Criteria
 - Given:** I am on the booking page, **When:** I select a slot and confirm booking, **Then:** I should receive confirmation message and be able to view the meeting time and location in the 'My Booking' page.
 - Priority
 - Must

- Justification of prioritisation /Trade-off
 - **High Impact:** For an "overwhelmed" student like Jack, face-to-face contact is the most effective way to de-escalate stress quickly.
 - **Trade-off:** Focuses on speed of booking over elaborate intake forms to ensure Jack doesn't give up due to the system's complexity.

Story ID: S4

- Feature: **FAQ**
- Title: Time-Saving Self-Service FAQ
 - User story
 - As a student, I want to be able to start a support thread directly from the FAQ page if I can't find the answer I need, so that I don't have to navigate through multiple pages to get help.
 - Acceptance Criteria
 - **Given:** I have searched for a topic in the FAQ, **When:** No results are found or the answer is insufficient, **Then:** A "Open New Support Request" button should be visible.
 - Priority
 - Should
 - Justification of prioritisation /Trade-off
 - **Efficiency:** Jack is busy; if he can find an answer in 30 seconds, he doesn't need to spend 30 minutes in a meeting.
 - **Trade-off:** Reduces the workload for counselors by filtering out repetitive questions, allowing them to focus more on Jack’s high-priority face-to-face sessions.

Student Persona C : Mei

Mei 	• MSc International student • Struggling with cultural adjustment and language barriers • Prefers written chat	• Support thread (with urgency) • FAQ
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Role/User type: MSc International Student

Bio: Mei is an international student who is currently struggling with cultural adjustment and the language barrier. She finds real-time, face-to-face English conversations stressful and prefers written communication where she can take her time to compose her thoughts.

Goals:

- Communicate at her own pace in writing to overcome language barriers and keep a digital record for reassurance.
- Maintain emotional health and seek reassurance when feeling overwhelmed by high-pressure UK academic deadlines and requirements.

Pain points:

- Fear of not expressing herself well in spoken English and feeling isolated by the language barrier.
- Struggling with complex UK academic requirements (like referencing) and looming dissertation deadlines.

Story ID: S5

- Feature: **Support thread** (Chat History & Urgency)
- Title: Asynchronous Support with Urgency Signaling
 - As a student, I want to complete a brief questionnaire when starting a request so that the system can accurately assess my needs and provide immediate safety resources if I am in crisis.
 - Acceptance Criteria
 - **Given:** I am starting a new request, **When:** I answer the questionnaire, **Then:** If my answers indicate high risk, a "Contact Emergency Services" pop-up must appear immediately.
 - Priority
 - Must
 - Justification of prioritisation /Trade-off
 - **Accessibility:** Essential for international students who need time to process English.

Story ID: S6

- Feature: **FAQ**
- Title: Peer-Validation FAQ
 - User story
 - As a student, I want to access a list of common questions and answers so that I can find quick solutions and feel reassured that other students share my concerns.
 - Acceptance Criteria

- **Given:** I am on the help page, **When:** I search for a topic (e.g., "International student support" or "Academic writing"), **Then:** I should see a list of categorized, commonly asked questions with clear, detailed answers.
- Priority
 - Should
- Justification of prioritisation /Trade-off
 - **Emotional Support:** Helps Mei realize she is not alone, reducing her sense of isolation.
 - **Resource Management:** Diverts common queries away from the support threads, allowing counselors to focus on the urgent, personalized requests Mei might send.

Counselor Personas

Counselor Persona A: Sarah

Sarah 	• University Wellbeing Officer • Overwhelmed by manual booking tasks • Needs status tracking	• Support thread • Booking
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Role/User type: University Wellbeing Officer.

Bio: Sarah manages the day-to-day operations of the university's mental health center, coordinating workshops and counseling sessions for hundreds of students. She is currently overwhelmed by manual administrative tasks.

Goals:

- To reduce administrative overhead and ensure all available support slots are filled efficiently
- To manage all student concerns and conversation statuses in one centralized place.

Pain Points:

- Spends hours replying to emails to schedule appointments, leading to frequent double-bookings or missed "walk-in" opportunities.

- Inefficient systems make it difficult to track which students are waiting for a reply and which have already been assisted.

Story ID: S7

- Feature: **Support Thread** (Status & Dashboard)
- Title: Centralized Case Management Dashboard
 - User story
 - As a Counselor, I want to see the status of each thread (e.g., 'Waiting' or 'Replied'), so that I can prioritize urgent requests and manage my caseload effectively.
 - Acceptance Criteria
 - **Given:** A student has sent a message that I haven't read, **When:** I look at my dashboard, **Then:** The thread should be marked with a "**Waiting**" badge.
 - **Given:** I have sent a reply and am waiting for the student's input, **When:** I view the thread list, **Then:** The status should be displayed as "**Replied**".
 - Priority
 - Must
 - Justification of prioritisation /Trade-off
 - **Operational Clarity:** Eliminates the "status confusion" Sarah currently faces with email, ensuring no student is left without a response.
 - **Trade-off:** Focuses on status visibility first to organize existing chaos before adding more advanced analytics features.

Story ID: 8

- Feature: **Support Thread** (Priority List)
- Title: Urgency-Based Prioritization
- User Story
 - As a Counselor, I want to see a priority list of students who need help the most, so that I can provide support in the proper order of urgency.
- Acceptance Criteria:
 - **Given:** Students have completed the urgency questionnaire, **When:** I view my dashboard, **Then:** I should see a sorted list of requests based on their urgency level.
 - **Given:** I am reviewing a request, **When:** I view the request details, **Then:** the priority level should be clearly displayed.
- Priority
 - Must

- Justification of prioritisation /Trade-off
 - **Clinical Safety:** Flags high-risk cases for immediate intervention , preventing counselors from overlooking crises while managing routine requests.
 - **Triage Efficiency:** Upgrades basic status tracking to a professional triage system , enabling counselors to sort high caseloads by urgency to prevent "status confusion".

Story ID: S9

- Feature: **Booking**
- Title: Appointment Management
 - User story
 - As a Counselor, I want to manage my specific working days and cancel sessions when necessary so that the booking system accurately reflects my availability.
 - Acceptance Criteria
 - **Given:** I am managing workshops, **When:** I create or edit a workshop with time and location details, **Then:** the workshop information should be updated.
 - **Given:** I am managing a workshop, **When:** I add or remove participating students, **Then:** the participant list should be updated accordingly.
 - **Given:** An emergency arises, **When:** I cancel a session in my calendar view, **Then:** The specific time slot is removed from the calendar and is no longer available.
 - Priority
 - Must
 - Justification of prioritisation /Trade-off
 - **Time Saving:** Directly addresses Sarah's primary pain point of spending hours on scheduling emails.
 - **Error Reduction:** Prevents the double-booking issues that occur with the current manual system.

Counselor Persona B: Oliver

Oliver 	• Hoping to provide approachable outreach • External Professional Counselor	• Support thread • FAQ
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Role/User type: External Professional Counsellor.

Bio: Oliver is a licensed therapist who provides part-time support for the university. Known for his approachable and kind demeanor, he focuses on proactive outreach to ensure students don't feel isolated

Goals:

- To reach students who are too intimidated to book a formal session
- To provide immediate, evidence-based advice to prevent students from reaching a crisis point

Pain Points:

- Students often wait until their situation is critical because the threshold for seeking help feels too high
- Answering the same common questions repeatedly is time-consuming and reduces the time available for personalized support

Story ID: S10

- Feature: [Support Thread](#) (Casual Engagement)
- Title: Low-Threshold Chat Support
 - User story
 - As a Counselor, I want students to rely on me through an informal chat thread so that they feel comfortable seeking help without the pressure of a formal appointment.
 - Acceptance Criteria
 - **Given:** A student is logged in and feeling hesitant to talk in person, **When:** They send a message through the Support Thread, **Then:** The interface should feel like a familiar chat, and I should be able to reply directly within the same thread to maintain a continuous, friendly conversation.
 - Priority
 - Must
 - Justification of prioritisation /Trade-off

- **Early Intervention:** This is essential for Oliver's goal of reaching students before they hit a crisis.
- **Trade-off:** While less structured than a formal session, it provides a vital "safety net" for students like Rory who find the threshold for help too high.

Story ID: S11

- Feature: **FAQ** (Resource Management)
 - Title: Shared Knowledge FAQ
 - User story
 - As a Counselor, I want to provide a list of frequently asked questions so that students can find reassurance and common solutions independently, saving my time for complex cases.
 - Acceptance Criteria
 - **Given:** There are common concerns shared by many students, **When:** I populate the FAQ section with clear, supportive answers, **Then:** Students should be able to browse these topics to realize they are not alone and find immediate answers.
 - Priority
 - Should
 - Justification of prioritisation /Trade-off
 - **Efficiency:** Reduces repetitive administrative and advisory labor.
 - **Trade-off:** An FAQ cannot replace personalized counseling, but it serves as a powerful tool for peer validation and quick self-service.
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